

Pronghorn Habitat Survey — Field Observations Log

Project

Pronghorn habitat survey, joint Doña Ana County Environmental Services / NM Department of Game and Fish. Field lead: Sofia Delgado (Game and Fish). Co-lead: Ian Salazar (county). Habitat mapping with GPS, vegetation transects, and direct sighting counts.

Field dates

Spring 2026 cycle: April 11, April 25, May 9, May 23. Fall 2026 cycle: September 12, September 26, October 10, October 24. Five-person team per outing. Pre-dawn departure (05h30 from Las Cruces); on-site by 07h00.

Sites surveyed

Five plots across the eastern flank of the Organ Mountains and the Tularosa Basin transition zone. Each plot revisited each cycle for direct comparison. Coordinates and elevation profiles in the GIS layer (county GitLab read-only mirror).

April 25 observations — Plot 3 (Tularosa transition)

Direct sightings: 14 individuals (one bachelor group of six males; one mixed group of eight including three females showing late-pregnancy behaviour). Vegetation transect: cholla cover at 22% (up from 18% in 2025 baseline). Forage grasses in fair condition; recent rain showing.

Notes: the pronghorn used the same approach line we observed in fall 2025 — they cut a diagonal across the southwest corner of the plot. Sofia thinks it's a learned route. Worth flagging in the habitat-connectivity section of the report.

September 26 observations — Plot 1 (Organ foothills)

Direct sightings: 9 individuals (mixed group). Vegetation: drier than usual for September. Monsoon was thin this year — confirmed in the OpenWeather log Ian keeps cross-referenced.

Wildlife photography: Nikon DSLR, 200mm telephoto. Photographed three of the nine at a safe distance. Best frame at f/5.6, 1/500s, ISO 400. Submitted to the project's Vimeo archive.

Methodological note

We coordinate sighting counts with the camera-trap pulls Sofia's team conducts independently. Camera-trap data is more reliable for absolute numbers; direct sightings catch behaviour and group composition that the cameras miss. The two together are stronger than either alone.

Joint report

Joint report due Friday November 13, 2026. Sofia drafting the habitat section. Ian drafting the connectivity section and the vegetation transects. Cross-review one week before submission.